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## 6.1 Benefits of Community Colleges and Accreditation

### **Focus Questions:**

- *Do all community colleges have the same tuition policies for international students?*
- *What is a 2+2 agreement? Is it more or less expensive than completing all four years at a four-year college?*

### **Why Attend a Community College?**

- They can provide an *easier transition* to the culture of American education for international students. There are lower admission requirements, a greater range of students, and often dedicated staff devoted to helping students with cultural, language, and study challenges. In addition, they often have smaller classes and smaller teacher/student ratios.
- They can allow international students with *lower grades/test scores* to (a) get into a degree program because of their more open admissions criteria and (b) improve their academic performance to the point they *can* transfer to a four-year college/university.
- They can often offer robust *English-language upgrading courses* and tutoring services. What's more they often require lower (or no) TOEFL scores from international students than four-year colleges/universities, so being highly proficient in English is not as crucial to beginning a course of study. They also generally have good career counselling services, dedicated as they are to helping students find the

employment they want.

- Community colleges can offer *excellent associate degrees and certificates in their own right* (i.e., without an eventual transfer) that provide job-ready and demanded skills in the American and global economy. The *facilities and the technology* they offer students are in some cases outstanding.
- American community colleges can be a *less expensive entry point into American higher education* because their tuition rates are much lower at the freshman (1st year) and sophomore (2nd year) level. This is important because many international students are self-funded with limited options for financial aid.
- They can be a *less expensive way to obtain a bachelor's degree* (except in cases where students have received a university scholarship). There are many excellent community colleges that have "2+2" transfer agreements with four-year colleges. Attending the first two years of a degree at a community college then transferring for the latter two years to a four-year college/university is almost always less expensive than doing all four years at a college/university.
- Some four-year colleges and universities even *offer guaranteed admissions* to graduates of the community colleges with which they have transfer arrangements.

## Considerations

Though choosing to study at an American community college has many advantages for international students, it is important for the agent to investigate whether the college charges more tuition to international students than to domestic students. This may be quite variable; some states have agreements with countries regarding tuition, some colleges have the ability to waive fees for a certain number of students, and some colleges even charge international students three times more in tuition than domestic students.

Additionally, one obstacle for some international students will be the lack of campus housing at many of these colleges. Only 28% of community colleges offer on-campus housing. In many cases, students will have to arrange for

off-campus accommodations. Often, community colleges will offer assistance for international students to find off-campus housing, whether it be an apartment, shared housing, or a host family.

## Governance and Accreditation

As with four-year colleges and universities in the US, a board of directors in each state generally governs community colleges. This board is sometimes appointed by the state's governor.

Accreditation of American community colleges occurs as it does for all colleges and universities in the US, as described in Section 2. As with any school the student is looking into, only American community colleges that are members of a recognized accrediting body should be considered as a valid study option. Check [CHEA's site](#) for a list of community colleges that are accredited.

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